The Believing Child

By Zenna Henderson

(to audience) No one seeing me sitting here could possibly know that a terrible problem is gnawing at me. In fact, I can't believe it myself. It couldn't possibly be. And yet I've got to solve it. I have LOTS of time—I have until 2:15. What will I do if 2:15 comes and I haven't got through to Dismey?

INTRODUCTION

Jiminy Cricket, side-kick and fictional embodiment of Pinocchio's conscious tells us, "Anything is possible if you just believe." In this story, a child takes this quote to a new extreme.

Dismey is a lonely, tormented first grade child of migrant workers, but her teacher discovers she is a believing child—someone who so strongly believes what she is told, that it becomes true.

But what happens when she realizes that she possesses the power of magic, without understanding the consequences? The Believing Child by Zenna Henderson

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(to audience) I welcomed [Dismey] to my first grade classroom. I was used to frightened withdrawn children, terrified by coming into a new school, but nothing [was] quite so drastic as Dismey. No talking, no laughing, no smiles, or even tears. [But she] came slowly to life in the classroom: drawing, painting, number work, reading . . . But all the rest of the classroom activities paled to insignificance as far as Dismey was concerned to the wonder of story time. Dismey believed without reservation in the absolute truth of every story she heard.

This [made] her completely vulnerable to Bannie and Michael. One day I found her crying out by the sidewalk. Tears were falling without a sound as she rubbed with trembling desperation at the sidewalk.

TEACHER: What's the matter Dismey? What are you doing?

DISMEY: *(crying)* My mamma. I hurt my mama! I stepped on a crack. I didn't mean to but Bannie pushed me. And now my mama's back is busted.

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TEACHER: Oh, Dismey, honey! 'Step on a crack and break your mother's back' isn't for true! It's just a singing thing the children like to say. It isn't really so.

(to audience) We finished the first of the Oz books and were racing delightedly into "The Magic of Oz," and there it was! Right on page 19! We all looked at it solemnly. We wrote it on the board. We contemplated it with awe. *A real live magic word!* All we had to do now was to learn how to pronounce [it].

Therein lay the difficulty. We considered the word—PYRZQXGL. We knew all the letters in it, but there were no vowels except "and sometimes Y". How could you sound out a word with no vowels and no place to divide it into syllables?

TEACHER: We'll have to be careful even trying to say it, though. Because if you do find the right way to pronounce it, you can—well, here it tells you— '. . . transform anyone into a beast, bird or fish, or anything else, and back again, once you knew how to pronounce the mystical word' . . . You could even change yourself. Wouldn't it be fun to be a bird for a while? But . . . birds can talk in the Land of Oz . . . can they talk here?

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(to audience) The solemn consensus was no, except for parakeets and mynah birds.

TEACHER: So, if you changed yourself into a bird, you couldn't ever change yourself back. So, you better be careful if you learn the way to say it.

DONNA: *How DO you say it, Teacher?*

TEACHER: I've never found out. I'll have to spell it every time. Maybe someday I'll learn it, *then* when it's Quiet Time, I'll turn you all into Easter Eggs, and we'll have a really quiet Quiet Time!

(to audience) [I watched as] Dismey bent over a piece of paper, carefully copying [the word] from the board, her mouth moving to the letters.

[Later], the clamor and noise finally settled down to the happy hum of Quiet Time, and I sighed and

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relaxed, taking a quick census of the room. I straightened and checked again.

TEACHER: Where's Dismey? Does anyone know where Dismey is?

DONNA: *She went to the restroom with me . . . She's afraid to go alone. She thinks a dragon lives down in the furnace room and she's scared to go by the steps by herself.*

TREESA: Maybe she go'd to beeg playgroun'. We don' s'pose to go to beeg playgroun'."

(to audience) Then I heard Bannie's high embarrassed giggle

TEACHER: Bannie and Michael, come here. Where is Dismey?

BANNIE: We didn't do *nothing.* We just put a rock on her shadow! We told her she couldn't move.

(to audience) The playground was empty, [then] I turned the corner of the Old Building, and there she was, straining and struggling, her whole self pulling desperately away from the small rock that lay on her

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shadow. I saw—or thought I saw - the shadow itself curl up around her knobby, chapped ankles.

TEACHER: Dismey! DISMEY!

DISMEY: Teacher! Oh, teacher . . .

(to audience) I had my arms around her, trying to warm her stiff little hands.

TEACHER: But, Dismey, honey, it isn't so! You could have come back to the room anytime! A rock can't hold your shadow! It isn't true!

(to audience) *But, I had to move that rock* before I could pick her up and carry her back into the room. I believed that I had felt the tug of a tethered shadow. I was out of my depth – completely.

Children bounce back amazingly. The next day—that's today! – started normally enough. Michael and Bannie had the devilish light flickering in their eyes again. Dismey had a small smile that turned up the corners of her mouth a little. Afternoon recess came and went. The tide of children flowed across the floor for story time.

TEACHER: Bannie and Michael, I don't. . .

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(to audience) Then I felt a huge sinking inside of me. My eyes flew to Dismey. She returned my look, the smile still bending her mouth.

TEACHER: Where's Bannie and Michael?

HANNERY: They tol' me they wuz go to beeg playgroun'. They alla time sneak up there.

DONNA: *Maybe they didn't hear the bell . . . when you play by the Old Building, sometimes you don't.*

(to audience) I looked at Dismey. She looked back. Her small, pointed tongue circled the smile and then disappeared. I looked away, uncomfortable. After the group went back to their seats and became immersed in their work, I called Dismey quietly up to my desk.

TEACHER: Where are Michael and Bannie?

DISMEY: Out on the playground . . .

TEACHER: Why didn't they come when the bell rang?

DISMEY: *(with a little smile)* They couldn't hear the bell ring.

TEACHER: Dismey, why couldn't they hear the bell?

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DISMEY: 'Cause I changed them . . . I changed them into rocks.

TEACHER: Changed them? Into rocks?

DISMEY: Yes . . . they're mean. They're awfully mean. I changed them. *(smiling again)*

TEACHER: How did you do it? What did you do?

DISMEY: I learned the magic word. I can say it right. You know, the one you read to us. That PYRZQXGL.

(to audience) Her voice fluttered and hissed through a sound that raised the hairs on the back of my neck.

TEACHER: And . . . it . . . WORKED!

DISMEY: Why, sure . . . you said it would. It's a magic word. Mama told me how to say it. She said how come they put words like that in a kids' book. That's not a word for kids. But she told me how to say it anyway. See?

(to audience) She picked up the stapler from my desk.

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DISMEY: Be a baby rabbit — PYRZQXGL!

(to audience) And there was a tiny gray bunny nosing inquisitively at my blotter!

DISMEY: Be what you was before . . . PYRZQXGL!

(to audience) The bunny started slightly, and the stapler fell over on its side. I picked it up. It felt warm. I dropped it.

TEACHER: But—but . . . where are the boys, Dismey? Do you know?

DISMEY: I guess so. *(frowning)* I guess I remember

TEACHER: Go get them. Bring them to me.

(to audience) She looked at me quietly for a moment, her jaw muscles tensing, then she said, "Okay, teacher." So I sent her, heaven help me! A she came back and put three little rocks on the corner of my desk.

DISMEY: I guess these is them . . . Two of them are, anyway. I couldn't remember exactly which ones they was, so I brought an extra one.

(to audience) We looked at the rocks.

DISMEY: They're scared. I turned them into *scared* rocks.

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TEACHER: Do rocks know? Can rocks be scared?

DISMEY: I don't know . . . but if they can - they *are*.

(to audience) And there they lie—three rocks, roughly the size of marbles - and two of them are Michael and Bannie. And time is running out fast! I can't say the magic word. Nobody can say the magic word except Dismey.

I see only one possible course of action. I'm going to take a page from Dismey's own book—I'm going to be the believingest teacher there ever was. I believe. I believe that Dismey will mind me – she'll do as she is told. I believe, I believe, I believe . . .

TEACHER: Dismey, come here, please . . . It's almost time to go home. Here, take the rocks and go outside by the door. Turn them back into Michael and Bannie again.

DISMEY: I don't want to.

(to audience) It's NOT refusal! It's not refusal . . . it's just a statement . . .

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TEACHER: I know you don't. But the bell will be ringing soon and we don't want to make them miss the bus.

DISMEY: *(angry)* But they were awfully mean.

TEACHER: Yes, I know they were, but they've been rocks a long time—scared rocks. They know now that you can be mean back at them, so they'll probably let you alone and not bother you anymore. Go on, take them outside.

(to audience) The three rocks click together in her hand. She is going out the door. Now, I am waiting for the doorknob to turn again.

I believe, I believe, I believe . . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

NE State Qualifier
MI State Finalist

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